

REFLECTIONS ON MY PROGRESS TO DATE

I'D BEEN AWAY FROM HOME FOR SIX WEEKS DURING THE MIDDLE of winter, but in the spring I returned home in a bit of a depression. By May, the 2,500 shares of Angstrom I still owned were worth \$3,281, for a paper loss of \$1,719, while the 53 shares of Gillette had risen from \$79 to \$88, for a gain of \$477. In all, the \$10,920 I'd invested through Prudential-Bache had a current value of \$9,399, not including airplane tickets, phone calls, and other incidentals.

Meanwhile, the market as a whole had gone up more than 35 percent. My own losses were intolerable per se, and devastating in the light of the general advance. Every front-page article about the great bull market was a sad reminder of the thousands I should have made in these exciting times. No matter how optimistic you are at the beginning of each stock-buying cycle, eventually you'll remember the last time you vowed never to do it again. The stock-player's vow, "Never another share," is taken and forgotten over and over, just like the familiar hangover vow, "Never another drink."

The worst part was that my friends and acquaintances still thought I'd done spectacularly well. The mounting pressure to live up to their expectations was something else I had to face.

If I had it to do over again, I wouldn't have blabbed about the early paper profit in Angstrom, telling everyone within earshot how well I'd done. Also I would never have said things like, "Why bother with the racetrack where there's Prudential-Bache?" These remarks helped convince my friends I'd been a big success. Plus they'd seen the Dow Jones shoot straight up since the start of my journey and envied the way I'd put myself in the right place at the